

SERMON BENEATH THE SUNK BELL: ON THE MARSH REVENANT

Attend, ash-brothers and ash-sisters. Draw close, but do not mistake nearness for safety. The mud remembers the foot. The reed remembers the hand. The drowned ground keeps its counsel until it rises to speak.

I speak today of the Marsh Revenant.

Not as a beast for children's warnings, nor as a mere corpse dragged upright by foul water. The Marsh Revenant is a siege-breaker, and this is its lesson: every wall believes itself eternal until something comes that does not tire before it.

Look upon it in the mind's eye. It appears as a corpse-like figure burdened with marsh-wet decay, its every motion heavy with stagnant earth. Yet beneath that rot lies the grim solidity of a breaker of walls. It does not creep like a thief. It does not rage like a beast. It advances with the weight of ruin made flesh.

Fortified resistance—hear those words and hold them tightly—does not endure before it. The gate may be barred. The stones may be braced. The defenders may gather behind their shields and tell one another that stone is stronger than mud, that breath is stronger than silence, that the living must outlast the dead.

Then the Marsh Revenant comes.

It comes without haste, and therefore without mercy. It projects tireless, impersonal hostility. There is no plea to answer, no bargain to strike, no wounded pride to soothe. It does not hate the wall. It does not hate those behind it. It simply advances, as the dead advance when *summoned by no kindness and restrained by no fear*.

And when it reaches the fortification, defense becomes desperation.

Remember this, not to surrender your gates, but to know what your gates are for. A wall is not salvation. A barricade is not deliverance. Defenses are tools placed in trembling hands, and all tools fail when worshiped as gods. The Marsh Revenant teaches that whatever is built may be broken, and whatever stands may be made to kneel.

Yet do not call the creature cruel. Cruelty belongs to those who

choose. The Marsh Revenant chooses nothing. It is the revenant of stagnant, hostile ground, and its silence is the silence of earth that has swallowed too much. It advances with the inevitability of the dead.

So watch the walls. Mend what may be mended. Guard the living. And when the marsh begins to move, do not waste your last breath declaring that it cannot.

The dead have never required our belief.